# The Blue Flowers

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The first thing I noticed when I stepped off the train was the noise. Engines roaring, people talking, a boy announcing the latest *Tageszeitung*, only for five cents. Margaret wrapped her hand around my forearm and guided me through the crowds, weaving me around each person like thread through cloth. "*Bleib bei mir.* Stay with me," she said, as if I could go anywhere with her grip locked around my arm. As we left the station, the setting sun blinded me. Margaret, who didn't seem to mind, dragged me across the glittering pavement for what seemed like hours.

Just when I thought my arm might fall off, we reached an old house covered with mold. Margaret finally let go of my forearm and pounded at the door. "*Markov!*" she yelled. "*Öffne dich!* Open up!"

"*Kommen!* Coming!" called a rough voice. The door swung open and a man in an undershirt stepped out. "*Was willst du?*"

They spoke in quick German for a moment, Margaret gesturing toward me several times. With a sigh, the man called Markov ushered us into an old *Volkswagen* that smelled like grease and *Wurst*. He drove, and Margaret sat in the front. The man turned on the radio, and folk music blasted from the speakers. Margaret kept gazing out of the window. She hadn't looked at me once since we left the station.

"*Wohin gehen wir?*" I tried asking, getting drowned out by the music. I tried again, louder this time. "Where are we going?"

The man shouted back, gesturing at Margaret. "You're going to live with her for the summer. Since your mommy and daddy kicked the bucket, she—"

Margaret shoved him, hard. The car swerved. "*Halt die Fresse!*" she snapped. "Shut your mouth!"

"Alright, alright," Markov responded. No one talked after that.

I lay down in the back seat and closed my eyes.

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My eyes opened to Margaret shaking me. "*Aufwachen.* Wake up." Outside the window was a small village, with goats and farms and houses and green gardens. Margaret led me through the streets, gesturing at a cottage. "This is my house," she said, setting my trunk down. "Go inside. I'll be back later." I watched her disappear down the street, then turned and walked back toward the village.

Men hammered at a fence. A woman hauled water from a well. Goats bleated from behind houses. A few older boys sat on a stone wall. The tallest one noticed me first.

"*Hey, Kind!*" he called, prodding the others. "Hey, kid! You lost, or what? We can help you get back to mommy." His friends snickered.

I turned away and kept walking.

"Kid! Wait!" he called out again. "Don't go up the hill." At that word, the others went quiet. "She'll get you."

"Who?" I asked, before I could stop myself.

"The witch," he continued, pointing past me. "In that old house up there. She eats birds. And little boys."

I kept walking, slower now.

"Don't say I didn't warn you!" he called behind me.

At the edge of the village, I looked up the hill. A house sat halfway up, its windows dark, the chimney lopsided. Trees crowded around it like they were trying to keep it hidden.

I watched the house until the sun stung my neck.

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Over the next few weeks, I settled into something like a routine. Margaret came and went. I walked to the schoolhouse. My classmates didn't talk to me. But every day, without meaning to, I always stared up at that hill, at that dark house, sitting there like it was waiting for someone.

One afternoon, I passed by the edge of the village on my way home. The house was still there, like a dark blemish on the bright hill. I almost looked away.

But I saw something.

Through a small gap in the shutters, an old woman was sitting on a wooden chair. She wasn't a witch. She was just sitting there. Like she was waiting for something.

Then she turned her head, looking directly out of the window.

Was it toward me?

I ducked behind a fence. My heart thudded.

Did she see me?

Did she know I was there?

I didn't look back.

Back in Margaret's house, I kept glancing toward the window, even though I couldn't see the hill. I picked up a book and put it down. I played with the little soldiers I had brought from back home. But all I could see was her, sitting still, not moving.

No one noticed when I left the path and started up the hill the next day. The grass here was longer, and it brushed against my legs as I moved quietly through it.

The house looked worse up close. The paint was coming off the walls, and the shutters were closed. I walked to the front, where an empty, cracked flower pot sat by the door.

I stepped closer.

Should I knock? Should I open the door?

I could see every scratch on the dull doorknob. My hand hovered over it.

What if the woman was behind the door, right now, waiting?

What if someone saw me here?

What if she saw me here?

The door opened.

Her face was pale. She wore a dark shawl, and loose gray hair spilled from her head in strands. She didn't speak. She just looked at me.

My feet moved before I did, turning and running down the hill.

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I didn't go back the next day, or the one after that.

But the house saw me. The woman saw me.

Was she waiting for me to come back?

Three days later, I went back up the hill. She was sitting in the same chair, slowly rocking back and forth.

"I thought boys had better sense than to come up here," she said, half to herself.

I titled my head, confused. "I just came to this town."

She didn't reply.

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That afternoon, Margaret stopped me at the door. "*Wo bist du nach der Schule hingegangen?*" she interrogated, her arms crossed. "Where did you go after school? You weren't home."

"I just walked around."

"Walked around where?"

"Nowhere."

Margaret leaned closer, studying me. "Did you go up the hill?"

I looked down at the floor.

"I don't know what those other children told you, but it's dangerous up there. Stay away from that place," she ordered.

I didn't answer.

She shook her head. "When I find out which boy told you to go up there—"

"No," I said quickly. "No, it's fine. It's nothing, Mama—"

I froze.

The word hung in the silence between us.

Margaret turned quietly and went inside.

I stood in the doorway.

I hadn't called anyone "Mama" since she died.

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I found myself turning up the path to the hill the next day, opening the door myself. When the lady saw me, she straightened slightly in her chair.

She didn't say anything at first. But after a few minutes, she quietly asked, "Would you bring that inside for me?" A bundle of cloth was resting by the door, and I stepped forward and picked it up, carrying it through the door.

The house smelled like mildew. Dust floated carelessly in the light, drifting through the beams like tiny ghosts. A dirty kettle sat on the stove. A clock hung on the wall, moving slower than I thought. A faded photograph leaned against a jar on the shelf, which I set the bundle near.

When I turned, the woman was watching me from her chair. She looked even older up close. I could see every deep wrinkle etched onto her face, like lines on an old map. Her skin was thin and fragile, almost paper-like, and her tired eyes were sunken under heavy lids.

I stayed a moment longer, not sure if I should say something.

She didn't speak.

So I left.

I walked slower down the hill this time.

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On the way up the hill the next day, I stopped in the grass and plucked one of the tiny blue flowers that grew by the path. Its petals were soft and delicate, and its color was bright.

The woman was in the chair, her eyes closed, her head resting back against the old wood. She opened her eyes when I stepped closer.

I held out the flower in my open palm. "*Das habe ich für dich mitgebracht*," I said. "I brought this for you."

For a moment, she didn't move. Then, slowly, she lifted her hand and gently took it.

"Where did you get this?" she asked, looking down at the flower.

"They grow on the hill," I explained, confused. "There are hundreds of them. You didn't know?"

The lady's lips pressed together, and parted again. "My son used to bring me flowers like that," she said quietly.

She turned her head toward the shelf by the window, and I followed her gaze.

On the shelf was the same picture, leaning on a jar.

I stepped closer to the shelf.

Inside the jar rested a dried flower. Its petals had faded to a pale, almost colorless gray, its edges curled in.

"The war took him," the woman said.

It was so quiet I almost missed it.

I stared at the jar. "My mama and papa are gone too."

For a long time, the woman didn't say anything.

Then, behind me, I heard the creaking of the chair and the slow sound of feet.

Her arms wrapped around me, tiny and pale and cold and shaking.

She held me tighter than I thought she could.

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After that the visits blurred together.

Once the lady told me about her son, about how he used to carve shapes into the windowsill. She said the carvings were still embedded into the wood, hidden under the dust.

I talked about my mother, how she used to sing to me during the nighttime. I didn't remember the words, though, only the feeling of them.

After those visits, the woman started looking paler. Her hands shook and her voice became a whisper.

Sometimes she was asleep when I arrived. When that happened, I sat next to her, watching the dust float and dance. Another time I saw her staring at the wall, her mouth moving like she was trying to speak, but no words coming out.

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One time, the lady was staring out of the window again. She didn't look at me. I sat down on the floor like I always did.

Then her hand barely moved. She raised it toward a table, where a small book lay. Her fingers trembled, pointing toward it weakly. She held her hand there for a second, and then it fell back down into her lap.

I looked at the book, then at her. "Do you want me to read it?"

She didn't respond.

Hesitantly, I took the book from the table and cracked it open. Sitting down on a stiff, dust-covered armchair, I started reading.

The room made every word feel louder, especially when I stumbled over words. The woman didn't seem to mind. She didn't look at me or move. I kept going.

When I looked up, her eyes were closed.

Her chest rose.

And fell.

And stuttered.

And rose.

I closed the book and got up.

She stayed still.

I walked out of the house and down the hill, careful not to make a sound all the way.

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The door was shut the next day.

I stood there for a moment, then pushed it open.

The woman was sitting low in her chair. Her eyes were on the floor.

I sat down.

She finally spoke, her voice smaller than I had ever heard it.

"You shouldn't keep coming here."

I looked up.

She didn't meet my eyes.

"You should be outside," she continued. "With children. With sun. With flowers."

I didn't say anything.

"*Bitte*," the lady begged, her eyes still on the floor. "Please. Don't come back."

I stood.

She didn't look up.

The door clicked behind me.

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Three days later, despite what she said, I walked up the hill again.

The lady's face looked even paler, ghostly in the dim light. There were deep shadows under her eyes.

I stood at the bottom of the steps and waited, but I didn't know what I was waiting for.

She didn't move.

I didn't move.

The world turned.

Then she spoke.

"Why do you come here?"

Her voice was almost a whisper.

I didn't know what to say.

So I stood there, quietly.

She didn't ask again.

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The next morning, Margaret was at the door. "*Pack deine Sachen*," she said. "Pack your things. We're leaving tomorrow."

I nodded, but I wasn't listening. My mind was already focused on the old woman. *I have to tell her!*

As soon as Margaret left the house, I ran. I ran out of the door, past the houses, past the gardens, past the bleating goats. Past the people in the square, staring at me as I darted by them. Past the dirt path up the hill. Past all the blue flowers, drifting in the breeze.

But there was something wrong.

The house wasn't quiet. There were cabinets, books, chairs, stacked outside it. Two men were hauling a table outside the front door, and I rushed to them. "Why are you here?" I probed.

One of the men looked at me and snickered. "*Du hast nicht gehört?*" he asked. "You didn't hear? The old hag died. It was about time."

The old hag died.

The old hag died.

The old hag.

Died.

My heart dropped.

"She was holding on for a long time, too. We were all waiting for her to croak, eh?" he laughed, nudging the other man. The two brushed past me.

I stepped through the doorway.

Gone.

The clock on the wall.

The chair she sat in.

The jar.

The jar with the blue flower.

The jar was gone.

I frantically looked around the room.

But it wasn't anywhere.

She had kept it for so long.

Now it was gone too.

I sat down in the middle of the room, amidst the dust on the ground.

It felt like a shell.

An empty shell.

I stayed in it until the shadows covered me like a blanket.

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The next morning, the train station was crowded again. I barely noticed. The engines, the chatter, the newspaper boy, they all muddled together.

Margaret pulled me through the crowds, gripping my arm.

The ride home felt shorter.

Margaret led me through unfamiliar streets, to a house I barely remembered.

I went into the small room she had cleaned up for me.

The trunk was heavier than I remembered.

I clicked the latches open.

On top of my clothes sat the jar.

The jar with the blue flower.

I picked it up and turned it over in my hands.

Then I set it down beside me.

And I sat there by the door, watching the dust float in the light.